capabilities for such a role; they could be used only to retaliate. Nor is the Pershing II, which cannot even reach most Soviet strategic weapons, a potential first strike weapon. Its short flight time is not substantially different than that of the more capable and much more numerous SS-20's aimed at our European allies whom we are pledged to defend and most of whom have no nuclear capability of their own.

Our forces have very limited capability to strike Soviet silos. We're improving this capability only because we cannot accept this situation in which the Soviet Union holds such a clear advantage in counter force weaponry.

Even if we are to complete all planned deployments in the absence of an accord which limits them they will not match the number of Soviet weapons with a first strike capability. I feel that because the specialists disagree in some areas, let's arrange for them to meet and discuss their concern. A frank discussion of the respective assessments and reasons could perhaps clear up these misunderstandings, which are not based on fact.

In any event we have both agreed to the principle of a fifty per cent reduction of nuclear arms. Implementing that agreement is surely the first task of our negotiators at Geneva.

Let me stress once again that we are willing to reduce the weapon systems which the Soviet Union finds threatening so long as the Soviet Union will reduce those which pose a special threat to the United States and its allies. . . .

So far as defensive systems are concerned, I would reiterate what I wrote to you before: if your concern is that such systems may be used to permit a first strike strategy, or as a cover for basing weapons of mass